

Far from being straight, involves a series of rotational maneuvers known as the “cardinal movements of labor.” This curve, known as the “curve of Carus,” is thought to result from the evolution of humans from being on all fours to being upright. This caused the spine to curve, the pelvis to tilt, and gave a curve to the birth canal. Your pelvic floor muscles help the head rotate through the birth canal.

COPING IN THE SECOND STAGE

The second stage of labor can be a time when instinct takes over and you may find that you are oblivious to everything around you as you follow the overwhelming urge to push. You may have been concerned before labor about how you would behave during the delivery. Some women are worried that they will defecate while they are pushing. This is actually very common and it's natural to pass a stool during the delivery; you should rest assured that the nurses and doctors will be completely used to this. You may not even notice yourself that this has happened.

Rather than be concerned about how you will act, try to take encouragement from the fact that you now have more control over your labor and are actively pushing your baby out. You may find that you want to grunt or moan while pushing, or you may push quietly and intensely. Focusing on the imminent arrival of your baby will help you to persevere.

When to push

Your baby will start to rotate their head and shoulders to start the descent through your pelvis to be born, and you will feel the urge to bear down and push as this is happening.

Your doctor will help you focus and encourage you to push when you feel the urge, which will come naturally with a contraction. With each contraction, you will need to concentrate on pushing down deep into the pelvic area and bottom. It can help to put your chin on your chest and to bear down for as long as possible during a contraction, during which time you may need to take several steady breaths. You may feel like grunting and making noises when bearing down, or you may prefer to breathe deeply and quietly; you should do whatever you find helpful and works best. You will need to work with your body's instincts and adopt the position you find most comfortable and easy to give birth in. Pushing your baby out into the world takes a huge amount of effort and energy, but you have the ability and are very capable of doing this.

Your doctor and birth partner will encourage and support you throughout this stage and help you to believe in your ability to give birth.

PUSHING WITH AN EPIDURAL

If you have had an epidural, this can affect your awareness of when to bear down and push. If this is the case, your doctor will first check that your baby isn't showing signs of distress, and may then decide to wait a while for the head to descend farther down the birth canal before telling you to push. Alternatively, the doctor will feel the top of your uterus so that she is aware of when a contraction is starting and will then guide you to bear down and push.

Your baby's descent

The time it takes to push your baby out once he or she is deep within the pelvis can take around 30 minutes to one hour for a first labor, although this time may be considerably reduced in subsequent labors, sometimes taking just a few minutes. The combined force of the contractions (which are now around every two to five minutes) and your pushing moves your baby farther down into the pelvic outlet. As this occurs, the pressure on your back and rectum will intensify and you may experience a stinging